

influencer, with 613,000 organic followers and a sixpack. His girlfriend is a model and part-time communications student, and when she's not picking at her swimsuit bottoms in the salty waters of Cottesloe, she's snapping acai bowls through vintage filters.

Once, when I was a freelance fashion writer with a blog in the late noughties, when this sort of marketing was taking off, I was offered a \$1000 wardrobe from a swimwear brand in exchange for posting shots of myself in their new line of bikinis. Never mind that my last blog post had achieved about 35 clicks – the PR firm didn't even enquire. But these days, they ask for your 'numbers'. I have no beef with the 'social influencer' industry, but these are young men and women who cannot genuinely afford the lifestyle they portray, from the designer threads to the café dukkah eggs captured on smartphones; wearing freebies in exchange for hashtags and links.

Gen Y is a want-it-now generation, and there is no escaping the sense that someone has it better than you – their airbrushed life is right there on your phone. I've unfollowed a lot of fashion brands and influencers on my account; looking at 22-year-olds in outfits worth more than my weekly wage doesn't make me feel good about myself. Of course, you might be a saver who can switch off the racket on your Instagram feed. When dreamy images waft into your social media stream, and you're saving for a home, will you have the conviction not to click through and 'add to cart'?

Say no to the dress

I sought the insight of a counsellor who specialises in helping people with shopping problems, and learned you don't have to be at the extreme end of the spending scale, with an affliction that has permeated your everyday life, to borrow these saving techniques. There are tips and tricks used in the treatment of chronic shoppers that can be adopted by anyone who wants to tighten their finances and resist natural temptations while saving for a first home.

Michelle Laving, a Sydney-based registered counsellor whose practice has been set up for overs shoppers and overspenders, says this uncontrollable inclination is often referred to as the 'smiled-upon addiction'. Shopping addiction has not yet been formally classified in the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*, and with playful phrases like 'Shop